communities catering to vegetarians and Jains means that Maharashtrians and others who love their mutton and fish are often pushed to the margins.

Devendra Tandel of the Akhil Maharashtra Macchimar Kruti Samiti, an organisation of fisherfolk, claims the Koli (fishermen) community, the original inhabitants of Mumbai, are the ones suffering the most. He says it's not uncommon to see residents of the "vegetarian towers" demanding the removal of fish markets in the vicinity. "Religious practices are a private affair...they must not affect the constitutional rights of the people," says Tandel. On the other side are people like Shiv Sena leader (Eknath Shinde faction)and ex-MP Sanjay Nirupam who have sought action against the sale of non-vegetarian street food during the Navratri festival. "The question of cultural imposition doesn't arise...we are only seeking action against the cooking and sale of it on the roadside during Navratri," he says, pointing to a Supreme Court ruling banning roadside eateries (which, incidentally, applies to vegetarian vendors as well).

Right is Might

In Yogi Adityanath-ruled Uttar Pradesh, meat often becomes a political, cultural and religious flashpoint. Over the past few years, the state has witnessed a rising wave of anti-meat and anti-halal sentiment among the people. Moves like banning halal-certified meat products, cracking down on slaughterhouses, removing eggs in school mid-day meals and restricting or banning meat sales during Hindu festivals are often enforced through vigilante action, blurring the lines between government authority and public policing. "What's worse is the hypocrisy," says a meat trader in western Uttar Pradesh. "Many of those leading these bans enjoy non-vegetarian food behind closed doors. This is not really about religion or purity, it's about power, control and creating divisions," he says.

The trajectory can be traced back to one of the first major decisions of the Yogi Adityanath government in 2017. Days after assuming office, the administration launched a sweeping crackdown on 'illegal abattoirs', triggering widespread panic among those in the meat trade. Cloaked in the guise of implementing a 2015 National Green Tribunal order, the action also fulfilled a key campaign promise of the BJP. In November 2023, the UP Food Safety and Drug Administration issued a notification banning the manufacture, sale and distribution of halal-certified food products, except those meant for export. The latter stipulation exposes the duplicitous nature of state policy, as UP accounted for over 60 per cent of the 1.3 million tonnes of buffalo meat India exported in 2024.

Meanwhile, the state justified the halal ban as a move to protect 'public health' and enforce uniform standards. It claimed that certain organisations were using halal certification to gain unfair commercial advantage while pushing a divisive agenda. For good measure, after a complaint by a BJP youth wing member, a case was also registered against Muslim entities, including the Halal Council of India (Mumbai), accusing them of exploiting religious sentiments.

Symbolism has continued to drive policy. Since 2023, the state has observed November 25 as 'No Non-Veg Day' to mark the birth anniversary of sadhu T.L. Vaswani, an advocate of vegetarianism. During the Kanwar Yatra in the Hindu holy month of Shravan, the

THOSE FOR A MEAT BAN...



"WE HAVE TO MAINTAIN THE SANCTITY OF MAA NARMADA [THE RIVER]. WE ARE GOING TO BAN THE SALE OF MEAT AND LIQUOR IN ALL THE RELIGIOUS TOWNS ALONG ITS BANKS"

MOHAN YADAV, *Chief Minister, Madhya Pradesh*

"The question of cultural imposition doesn't arise...we only want action against cooking and sale of meat on the roadside during Navratri"

SANJAY NIRUPAM
Shiv Sena (Shinde faction)





"In our *teerth sthals*, there can be no consumption of meat or liquor... we'll build milk stalls for them [those selling meat/liquor], they can sell milk, that will bring back the age of Dvaparyug"

YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh, in Mathura, 2021

A PUNE-BASED BUTCHER SAYS THERE HAVE BEEN MORE INQUIRIES ABOUT JHATKA MEAT FROM HINDUS AFTER THE MALHAR BROUHAHA